

Sourdough Starter Care

Hi! Welcome to your new sourdough starter! It is really easy and simple to care for, but here is a guide to get you started as you begin the sourdough journey.

You'll need a few items to get started

- Unbleached flour. This starter is used to being fed Great Value unbleached all purpose flour. The bag looks like this:



(once the starter is established in your home, you can feed whatever flour you see best as long as it is unbleached. To change the flour, use a gradual method over several feedings. e.g., 75/25, 50/50, 25/75)

- Filtered water at room temperature. I use filtered water from my fridge and leave it out in a pitcher until room temp, but bottled water works too. Do NOT use distilled water.
- A digital food scale that measures in grams. It's worth the \$10-20 investment if you don't have one.
- A jar or other container large enough for your starter to double in size.

Once you bring your starter home, it will be ready to be fed in the evening. Your new sourdough starter has wild and active yeast that requires “food” to stay alive and give you the beautiful rise on your bread. Feeding your starter just means you mix the starter with water and flour so the yeast has something new to consume.

I recommend feeding at a 1:2:2 ratio.

This means 1 part starter, 2 parts water, 2 parts flour.

Example: 25g of starter, 50g of water, 50g of flour.

Or 50g of starter, 100g of water, 100g of flour. Etc.

To feed your starter, place your bowl on the digital scale and zero it out. Pour your desired amount of starter in, measuring in grams. Zero out the scale again and add double the amount of grams for water and flour. Mix. It should be a thick pancake-batter-like consistency. Cover lightly, but do not seal. The yeast creates a lot of

gas as it eats (this is what makes your starter rise) but if the gas has nowhere to go, your jar may explode. Use a paper towel and rubber band or leave the jar lid loose.

If you had leftover starter that you did not use for feeding in your bowl, discard into a trash can or pour into a separate “discard” jar kept in the fridge.

DO NOT POUR DOWN THE SINK.

So how often should you feed your new starter?

- If you keep your starter on the counter, it will need to be fed once a day (about every 24hrs).
- If you want to keep it in the fridge, I recommend feeding it once a week. Let it come to room temp and feed. Let the starter rise and fall, then put it back in the fridge.

If you go on vacation for longer than a week - don't sweat it! She will bounce back after 1 or 2 feeds. I've kept my starter in the fridge for 3 weeks without feeding and she rose on the first feed. They are resilient!

“Help! I've kept my starter in the fridge and I'm seeing this watery-murky liquid on top of my starter. Has it gone bad??”

- Nope! The liquid you are seeing is called “hooch”. It's a natural byproduct of the wild yeast and means your starter is really hungry. You can either pour that off before feeding or stir it in to give your sourdough a more “sour” flavor

Ready to bake??

I would recommend having a good idea of how long your starter takes to rise at your own house before jumping into baking a loaf. Starters will rise faster in homes that are warmer, and slower in homes that are colder. Every home has its own distinct bacteria, molds, & humidity. This plays a role in how your starter behaves, so take some time getting to know the behavior of your starter before baking.

Once you have an idea of how long it takes for your starter to rise, you need to feed your starter before baking. Give yourself plenty of time for it to rise. It will be ready to use when it has at least doubled in size, gone flat (no longer domed and rising), and you see lots of little bubbles on top.

That's it! Happy baking! Feel free to reach out to me with any more questions or troubleshooting :)